cobalt, 35% of its manganese, 30% of its tantalum, and 5% of its hardwood timber from Africa'. In 2003 China consumed 25% of global aluminium and steel production; 32% of iron ore and coal production; and 40% of the world's cement, figures that have probably risen since. China's imports from Africa are led by Angola, the second-largest single source of Chinese oil, followed by the Sudan and Nigeria, which account for 32% of oil imports.

Similar to Western counterparts, China's economic growth goes hand-in-hand with the need for new markets to sustain its industry. China's exports to Africa have increased by a factor of nine since 2000. But some 60% of Chinese exports to Africa go to just six countries – South Africa, Egypt, Nigeria, Algeria, Morocco and Benin. The export of machinery, automobiles, and electronic products, which now account for more than half of China's exports to Africa, is also on the rise.

In exchange for these exports, China also enforces on Africa's poorest countries its 'One-China Principle' – which insists that all countries must only recognise China, and that Taiwan is part of China. Taiwan remains a thorn in China's flesh. China is consequently using its economic and geopolitical power as well as its veto rights to punish African countries which have diplomatic ties with Taiwan even though the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) tolerates trade relations with Taiwan.

China needs Africa to strengthen its political position in global affairs. It therefore has to use the expansion of economic power – through its first two interests discussed earlier – to seek support from 54 African countries, which now represent over one-quarter of the UN's 193 members in institutions such as the UN Security Council, the United Nations Human Rights Council and the World Trade Organisation (WTO), where there are unending disputes and negotiations.

South Africa

South Africa has two main interests at play in Africa. First, there is its own influence as regional hegemon and its quest for political and economic expansion. This occurs through humanitarian aid and peacekeeping missions in war-torn countries. South Africa uses these missions as stepping-stones for economic conquests of new territories and conquests of territories previously exploited directly by Western countries.

South African capitalists have advanced in Africa via mining, banking, defence, retail and tourism, many of which require a supply of cheap energy. Second, there is the intermediary or sub-imperialist roles that South Africa plays between